2004 Toyota Matrix

$3,800 · 168,000 miles · Private seller · Palmdale, CA

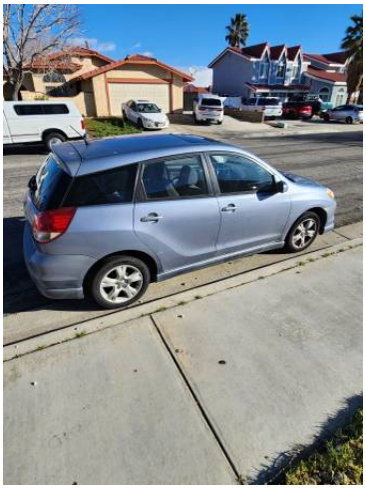
Seller: Private seller

Source: Craigslist

Listing: https://www.craigslist.org/view/d/palmdale-vehicle-for-sale/fDyPgztoaf5UbqhzRrJTjk

Report generated October 26, 2026 · Ridgecrest Car Finder









+ 2 more photos in the app.

Out-the-door price	Monthly cost to own	Reliability
$4,331	**$375**	**Good**
Set a budget in the Cost Calculator tab to compare.	loan + insurance + fuel + repairs + registration	4/5 · 3 recalls · 138 NHTSA complaints

Budget — buying it

Vehicle price	$3,800.00
Use tax (9.25%) — paid at DMV	$351.50
Vehicle license fee (0.65% of price)	$24.70
Registration + CHP fee	$108.00
Transportation improvement fee	$32.00
Title transfer	$15.00
Total out-the-door	$4,331.20
+ Pre-purchase inspection (you pay the shop)	$150.00

California taxes the full price — a trade-in does not reduce sales tax. DMV fees are estimates; the CA DMV fee calculator gives exact amounts.

Budget — paying for it

Down payment	$4,331.20
Amount financed	$0.00
Cash needed up front (down payment + inspection)	$4,481.20

Paid in full with your down payment — no loan needed.

Budget — owning it each month

Loan payment	$0.00
Insurance (estimate, liability)	$70.00
Fuel (1,000 mi/mo @ 27 MPG, $4.75/gal)	$175.93
Maintenance & repair reserve	$115.00
Registration renewal (÷12)	$14.56
Total per month	$375.48

Running costs without the loan: **$375/mo**. Estimated first-year cost of ownership: **$8,987** (out-the-door + inspection + 12 months of running costs + loan interest).

The repair reserve is set from the reliability rating and mileage: money to set aside, not a forecast.

Insurance

Coverage	Typical Ridgecrest range	Estimate used
Liability only (CA minimum 30/60/15)	$49–$112/mo	$70/mo
Full coverage (liability + collision + comprehensive)	$94–$243/mo	$135/mo

The budget above uses the **liability coverage** estimate ($70/mo). Get real quotes and enter one in the app to replace it.

• Vehicle class: typical car. Estimates assume an adult driver with a clean record; age, record, credit, and coverage limits change the price a lot.

• Ridgecrest is one of the cheapest places in California to insure a car (about $107–110/mo average).

• A lender will require full coverage. On an older, cheap car paid in cash, liability-only can make sense — but you'd pay for your own repairs after an at-fault accident.

• California's minimum (30/60/15) is low; $100k/$300k/$100k liability is commonly recommended.

• Ask about military/government discounts (NAWS China Lake), bundling, and low-mileage discounts.

Reliability

Rating: Good (4/5)

Toyota Matrix = Corolla mechanicals (1.8L 1ZZ-FE, 4-speed auto): among the most durable cheap commuters. Main watch-item on 2003-04 is oil consumption from the piston rings.

NHTSA data for this model year: 3 recalls · 138 owner complaints (18 involving a crash). Most complaints: Power Train (37), Air Bags (35), Vehicle Speed Control (15), Visibility (13), Electrical System (9), Structure (8).

Known issues for this model

• Oil burning on some 1ZZ-FE engines (2003-04)

• Sagging/worn engine mounts

• Takata airbag recall (passenger) - confirm done

• Rear hatch struts and A/C wear with age

Check on this car before buying

• Pull dipstick - full and clean? Ask how often they add oil

• Blue smoke on cold start

• Run VIN for open Takata recall

• Tire date codes / tread

• A/C cold in Palmdale heat

Notes

$3,800, 168k mi, automatic, FWD, clean title, blue. Posted 2026-10-21. Owner says well maintained (regular oil changes), brakes and water pump replaced ~7 months ago, straight body, good interior; tires are 'OK' but they suggest replacing. Tags due November - seller will keep them current. Stopped driving it after buying a bigger vehicle.

A Corolla underneath, with a hatchback that fits big catering orders. ~1.5 hr drive from Ridgecrest - text first. Budget ~$400-600 for tires.

Vetting checklist (0/12 done)

- [ ] Checked KBB/Edmunds fair price
- [ ] Recalls checked / completed
- [ ] Clean title in seller's name
- [ ] Test drive incl. highway & hills
- [ ] No overheating; coolant clean
- [ ] Pre-purchase inspection
- [ ] VIN decoded & matches listing
- [ ] History report (Carfax/AutoCheck/NMVTIS)
- [ ] Valid smog cert (< 90 days)
- [ ] A/C cold after 15+ min
- [ ] Tires OK (tread, dry-rot, DOT date)
- [ ] Written out-the-door price

All costs and insurance figures are estimates for planning, not quotes. Confirm fees with the CA DMV, rates with insurers, and the car's condition with an independent pre-purchase inspection.